

Jacob Kirkegaard interview: the sounds for themselves

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In late August 2023 I met composer and sound artist Jacob Kirkegaard for a talk about the ways in which he thinks about sounds, their origins and their agency. Kirkegaard is a highly original composer and sound artist that has a meticulous method for exploring sounds, and the traces that sounds make. He often engages with materials that make sounds that are not usually heard, reflected upon, or not even accessible to listeners. He stages them in ways that allows them to speak for themselves, and that allows the listener to frame and understand them in their own individual ways.

Works like *Crossfire* (2022), which contains recordings of guns and artillery being fired rapidly and intensively, and *Aion* (2006), where four abandoned spaces in the zone of alienation in the area surrounding the former nuclear power plant in Chernobyl, Ukraine, are made to resonate. Departing from these two works I was interested in discussing how Kirkegaard thinks about the politics of sound. In the case of Chernobyl, for example, he is allowing the unheard to be heard in a double sense: most people cannot travel to the Chernobyl site, and even if one can, the sounds that are heard in *Aion* are not accessible. As an artist he gives a site a sound that perhaps was not there before, or that was at least was not heard before, which may, or may not, have political implications I suggested to him.

Our discussion began in a mapping of the meaning, or meaningfulness of speaking about a politics of sound or, in other words, sounds as political utterance. Kirkegaard initially debates the idea that there is anything political about his works. What he intends for, he explains, is to explore a set of themes that allows for a free and non-judgmental listening that has no particular purpose other than to evoke the thematics embedded in the sound. The common thread in his practice, he continues, is at the most basic level concerned with what it is to be human. Works like *Labyrinthitis* (2007), *Testimonium* (2019) and *Membrane* (202) are evidence of such artistic and aesthetic intension.

Nevertheless, he continues, it happens that the contexts in the world changes which reconfigures the possible interpretations of the works in question. The Russian invasion of Ukraine, for example, has an impact on both *Crossfire*, with its evocation of sounds of war, and *Aion*, where the contemplative place as created by Kirkegaard now instead is put at the centre of a geopolitical conflict the scale of which we have not seen in post World War II.

Thus, although his work obviously is concerned with themes that has validity in the surrounding world it is not intrinsically concerned with commenting on these subjects on a level that makes the works themselves politically loaded. That world events occur after a work has been instantiated and which charges them with new meanings is interesting but does not in any substantial way change the core identity of the work, he claims. That their possible interpretations may be altered, and that they may be loaded with new meanings and frames of reference, different to how they were once conceived, does not make the work political.

This approach is part of Kirkegaard's view on his role as an artist. He is an artist and in this role he asks questions about what happens in the world. He uses his sensibility to create new surfaces for listening, to make listening possible where it was not previously possible. In this process he intends to allow the objects, the themes and the places to speak for themselves. They speak their own language, he says. The sounds found in Chernobyl, he takes as an example, "does not say yes or no, good or bad, left or right; they are not political." According to Kirkegaard he is in no position to tell the listener what or how to feel. It is solely the responsibility of the listener to figure out what they think. Kirkegaard is very firm on this point, he has no interest or wish to figure out what possible interpretations there are of his works, this is up to the listener. The sounds themselves are nothing but sounds and they make no judgments about political matters, nor do they have opinions, and this is precisely his point: the sounds are *not* political. There is plenty of other kind of sonic communication today that attempts to influence and manipulate the listener in one or another direction.

Space for sensuousness

Kirkegaard uses the metaphor of a *space for sensuousness* that allows the listener to seek out their own point of view, that is, what the listener senses from listening to the works. It is important, says Kirkegaard, to be clear that I have no interest in manipulating the listener in one direction or the other, or convince them that I am right or that I choose one thing over the other. However, this does not mean that he is neutral to the topics he raises, only that the listener should have agency and responsibility to create their own understanding. Kirkegaard says he is interested in instigating change in the world, but more than anything, to create a "breeding bed for a deeper kind sensuousness", one that is less dependent on the onslaught of information and opinions that dominate contemporary Western society.

Kirkegaard's own personal fears often plays a role in the way he picks the themes for his works. Fear of radioactivity, fear of war, or border walls, and the process of creating a space for listening to the objects that manifests this fear appears to almost have a therapeutical role in his practice. He obviously makes choices about what sounds to work with, and how, and through these choices he of course influences the outcome. The way he puts microphones and sensors on these objects are one of the more important aspects of his work. But the main objective is to allow for the objects to find their own way, and for the artist to take a step back. "They [the sounds] really speak for themselves" he says, and states that the abstraction that sound is compared to language actually makes them speak even more clearly.

Ethical aspects

Many of the Kirkegaard's works and working methods raises questions that are ethical in their nature both in terms of how they are conceived and the materials they engage with, and conceptually which may influence their perception. I was curious to learn how he thought about this. He raised the question concerning the societal attitudes that has changed dramatically over the last few decades. These are at the same time good, natural and problematic, but he has observed that a certain wokeness also has had an impact his practice. To explore difficult topics is essential to Kirkegaard's practice and if the boundaries for what is acceptable becomes too narrow, this obviously poses a threat to this

kind of artistic practices. There are those of his works, he says, that he would not have done today, but in an act of opposition to political correctness he still has an inclination to choose to do the politically *incorrect*.

Kirkegaard's fascination for the quality of the sounds that he records distinguishes him, as he puts it, from some of the sound artists that emanate from the visual arts whose relation to sound in some cases is purely conceptual. This quality that he is talking about has to do with a certain balance in the sound, "that the sound, purely acoustically, has some bass, some mid register, high end—that it has a quality that allows you to get *in to the sound*." It is clear that this has to do, at least in part, with the fact that Kirkegaard has his background in music. He is describing a method of working in which he sets in motion an iterative process, perhaps only partially controlled by him, out of which new things and new sounds appear. The listening that may appear out of this gives way for a mental state "that is right in between the alienated and the well known." He again points to the neutrality and the quality of the sound as factors that facilitate this.

In our discussion Kirkegaard often returns to, and emphasizes, that the role of his art is not to dominate the listener with conceptual and political truths. As an artist he is merely the facilitator, he allows me as a listener to understand something about the world I did not know before, but it is up to me to do the work. The ambition that the music should create a *sensuous space* that allows for this communication is both beautiful and challenging: "It is only here that you can actually tell what you really think." In this space there are no predefined expectations and no binary distinctions laid on you, and, as a listener you should have the freedom to develop your own opinion.

That this rare space, the *space for sensuousness* may be created through his music becomes clear when I explore Jacob Kirkegaard's works. He clearly succeeds with that ambition. His art pushes boundaries, as art should do, and does not shy away for the complicated questions. His pieces allow the sounds to stand out by themselves in all their beauty. I believe that the discussion on the nature of musical sounds in the way Kirkegaard frames it, as neutral and void of unequivocal meaning, brings forth an interesting side-topic.

Traditional music theory is saturated with metaphors that relate to the meaning of certain

sonic events, and harmony is probably the most salient one. A dominant chord is a sound with a specific inherent meaning. One of American composer John Cage's (1912-1992) greatest contributions that allowed for the move towards an aesthetic of sounds for themselves, the cornerstone of Jacob Kirkegaard's music, was to abandon harmony.

Another reference I come to think of after my discussion with Jacob Kirkegaard, which also has some relevance to Cage, is American transcendentalist philosopher Henry David Thoreau's (1817-1862) *Walden*. In a short passage he rejects the symbolic meaning of the sounds of the growing industrialism and points to our right to, by ourselves, define what musical meaning it has: "If the engine whistles, let it whistle till it is hoarse for its pains. If the bell rings, why should we run? We will consider what kind of music they are like. " (Thoreau, 1854, p. 105)